
Why Ilia Malinin Choked

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This essay was reprinted from David Epstein's newsletter [Range Widely](#). [Subscribe here](#). Read more of Slate's 2026 Olympics coverage [here](#).

American figure skater Ilia Malinin, known as the “Quad God” for his quadruple jumps, is the best in the world. He came into the Olympics not having lost a competition in *two years*. And then, on Friday, in his free skate in Milan, he fell apart.

Early in his program, he bailed out of his signature quadruple axel and did a single axel instead. He then nailed a different quad jump but bailed on another one, turning a quad loop into a double loop. Then, on another planned quad jump, he fell, and then he fell again. Something was obviously very wrong.

Bewildered, here is what he said afterward:

I just felt like all the ... traumatic moments of my life really just started flooding my head, and there were just so many negative thoughts that just flooded into there. And I just did not handle it.

I found his explanation to be powerful and eloquent; I'm glad he shared it. It also helps explain what happened.

Years ago, I spent some time interviewing psychologist [Sian Beilock](#), who studied “choking”: when someone fails, under pressure, to do something they've done a million times. Beilock, now the president of Dartmouth, was interested in the topic in part because she sometimes performed much better on practice tests than on the real thing in school, and because she was a talented soccer goalie who played the worst game of her life when the national team coach showed up to watch. So what's going on?

In a simplified nutshell, what's happening is that skills get “deautomated” under pressure. Think of when you learned to ride a bike or drive a car. At first, you had to think about every move. But with practice, you no longer had to pay attention to exactly how your feet were pedaling, or to your hand positioning on the steering wheel. Research by Beilock and others shows that stress and anxiety can undo that learned mastery. It can cause you to start consciously monitoring movements that have become automatic—your brain's explicit attention system hijacking what your body already knows how to do. Suddenly, you're more like a beginner again, thinking about every move. I once attended a sports psychology workshop where the instructor had people walk along a white line on the floor. We all did it with no problem. Then he put a similar-width beam between two tables and had us do it again; some people fell. Same line, more pressure.

So how can we make choking less likely?

A few of the suggestions Beilock shared with me had to do with keeping that conscious attention

system busy so it can't hijack your movements. Those were simple things like singing to yourself, counting backward, or focusing on some external mantra that might even be written on your hand or arm, where you can repeatedly refer to it. Those are in-the-moment tactics; Beilock also talked about something more structural.

She told me about the benefits of having a diversified identity. "I think we often think about professional athletes in terms of one self," she said. "And we know that when people have multiple identities—they're a mom self and a tennis-player self—they can turn it on sometimes and they're more relaxed other times. They often tend to be sort of psychologically buffered from failure."

Identity diversification has been a regular topic in my newsletter. I recently [talked to Brad Stulberg](#) about building an "identity house" with more than one room, and the most popular Range Widely post ever discusses [why hobbies are an advantage](#).

On top of Beilock's tips, there's another approach that's been useful for me: assuming that things will go wrong. Back when I was a competitive 800-meter runner, I sometimes got flustered by things going poorly in warmups. Maybe the schedule was off and so the warmup was too short or too long, or I was just extra nervous, or a shoelace tore off at the last second, or who knows what else. Eventually, I just started assuming that those things would happen, which made it unsurprising when they did, and it meant that I had already thought through backup plans for how to proceed. And I think this is relevant not just to sports.

Back when I gave my [first TED talk](#), there was a technical malfunction about 30 seconds into it. The computer monitors and clock just blinked off all at once. The TED staff stopped the session, and people started rushing around the stage. There I was, standing awkwardly on a red circular carpet, elevated above the audience. I remember Cameron Diaz smiled at me, so that was nice. Fortunately, I had thought about literally this situation beforehand. When I tried to envision a realistic worst-case scenario, it was that the slides didn't work. If that happened, I decided, I'd give the talk anyway, altering one spot that depended on audio and tweaking a few other things.

After a few minutes, when it seemed as if they weren't going to be able to get the tech working, I told the audience I was going to give the talk anyway—charades if needed. Luckily, that was just before the screens blinked back to life, and the talk proceeded as normal. If you watch the end of the talk (the tech troubles didn't get posted), you can see me do a "Phew!" gesture as I walk away; it was my nod to the tech difficulties.

I don't think there's even close to a foolproof method for dealing with the kind of pressure Ilia Malinin was facing. But the more I've prepared for things to go wrong, the less power those moments have when they arrive.

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